

Comments for Planning Application DM2025/01591

Application Summary

Application Number: DM2025/01591

Address: Ambulance Station Dorset Road Belmont SM2 6JH

Proposal: Change of use from Sui Generis (Ambulance Station) to mixed use Classes F1 (Places of Worship) and F2 (Community Hub) involving the erection of a part one, part two storey front and side extension, increase in height to part of building and provision of cycle and refuse stores.

Case Officer: Polly Davidson

Customer Details

Name: Dr Amir Hassan

Address: 39 Holland Avenue Cheam SM2 6HT

Comment Details

Commenter Type:

Stance: Customer made comments in support of the Planning Application

Comment Reasons:

Comment: I am really excited about this proposed development

I was born and brought up in this area, moving to the Belmont/Cheam location since 2004. At that time there was 1 muslim family on the road and now there are 8. This demographic change is replicated on other roads around the area. This development is just a natural requirement for the diverse population in the local area.

However the main benefit of this proposed build and the idea of a joint place of worship/community centre is that the community is at the centre of this redevelopment of the derelict site. This centre will be open to people of all faiths and none, to come and share the facilities in various forms and to break down the perceived barriers that are present between people.

I am a doctor working as an Emergency Medicine Consultant and Divisional Medical Director at Epsom and St Helier as well as the Medical Director for Sutton Health and Care which gives me an insight into the needs of the population and how we, using this community centre, can help.

1- The elderly. Loneliness is one of the common problems afflicting the elderly either living alone or with their partners - being socially isolated causes many problems with mental health for these residents as well as affecting their physical health. With this centre, we have 2 options, both of which can happen:

a. Pairing with Age UK (Sutton) to help run a visiting service to drop in and talk to people. By working with partners who are experienced in this we would work within already established frameworks and governance and learn from their experience in this

b. Using the community centre for drop in/day centre to have a cup of tea, biscuits or samosas!

The advantage of this is that they would be able to get out of the house and meet different people as well as try out different foods.

2- Healthcare. There are vast inequalities in our area. You have several affluent areas surrounding

the site, but also areas of deprivation. Having seen this first hand in my Emergency Department, more work needs to be done to help address this.

a. Health clinics- measuring simple things like BP, sugars for diabetes, healthy living advice are all possible along with simple point of care testing. This is not meant to replicate NHS care, but supplement it, where people are struggling to get hold of GP care, or find that they are not given the time to go over their problems

b. Dental care - the provision of NHS dentistry is poor in all areas. What comes into the Emergency Department is sometimes shocking. We have several dentists in the area and although there will not be the ability to treat patients, there will be able to do simple check-ups and advice

3- Social care. There are many homeless people around the area. This maybe for various reasons as to why they do not engage with council services, however we still have a responsibility as a community to support them. We would aim to work with other charities to provide meals for this group as well as other support as required.

Along with that is consideration of creation of a foodbank as many are struggling with the cost of living and eating healthily is not cheap. Again, this affect I see in my services.

4- Education. My children went to the Avenue Primary School and I got them tutored to support them in their application to grammar school. I remember one parents evening where I heard a mother pleading with the headmaster for support for her child with the 11+ exams and all he could advise was to buy books which she could not afford. This broke my heart and as someone who came from a very poor background, I understand the benefit of a good education in bettering yourself and your community. There needs to be levelling up to ensure all children have access to all the excellent facilities this borough has to offer

a. Free tutoring. This will be focussed on general academia to support children's learning in their school work. We would aim to work with the schools (not separate to it) to give that extra support to children who need it.

b. School Visits - children need to learn about different cultures, religions and people and only by doing this will we gain understanding of each other, decreasing misconceptions that are rife on social media.

For both of these activities we would expect to implement the full safeguarding protocols and governance around programmes for children

These are just some of the ideas that we can put into action when we have the community centre established, however they are not just empty promises as the resources are there to action this, whether it is professionals dealing with healthcare or some of the youth helping with tuition. We just need a home for this to become a reality.

There will be people objecting to potential traffic issues, crowding, school issues and noise. I would just say that we have been running the Friday prayers as well as the Ramadhan worship in the evenings (the 2 busiest activities) for the last 5 years in the St Johns Church Hall on Northdown Road for the last 5 years. This is just 200 metres away from the proposed location on the other side of the school, with no or minimal complaints from residents and no problems with school pick ups on the Fridays.

